

In posh area, ‘indoor Mass. and Cass’ infuriates

Condo owner, others arrested again over alleged ‘drug den’

By Sean Cotter
GLOBE STAFF

The stately brick building on West Newton Street seems no different from its neighbors in this tony South End neighborhood in the shadow of the Prudential Center, where countless pedestrians clutching public-radio tote bags or walking sweater-clad dogs pass by on routine affairs.

But inside, police and neighbors say, dozens of people each day have crowded into the first-floor unit, engaging in drug use and other nuisances on a scale a prosecutor likened to the open-air drug market known as Mass. and Cass. There are so many people coming and going that at times they spill out into the narrow hallway shared by other residents.

“It’s a drug den,” said Ashley Forest, who lives downstairs from the owner of the condo, Michael F. Collins. “It’s been absolutely surreal.”

On Wednesday, Boston police raided Collins’s apartment at 231 W. Newton Street, the second time in two months. In both cases, they arrested the 66-year-old Collins and his husband, 37-year-old Schanwat “Sam” Wilailak; 10 others have also been charged with possessing drugs ranging from crack cocaine to fentanyl.

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DAVID LYNCH 1946-2025

Uncovering a dark reality in the stuff of dreams

By Harrison Smith
WASHINGTON POST

David Lynch, the surrealist filmmaker who bridged the mainstream and avant-garde, exploring the sinister recesses of the human psyche — and the mysteries behind America’s white picket fences — with an unsettling blend of melodrama, whimsy, and nightmarish horror, has died. He was 78.

His family announced the death in a Facebook post on Thursday but did not share additional details. “There’s a big hole in the world now that he’s no longer with us,” they wrote. “But, as he would say, ‘Keep your eye on the doughnut and not on the hole.’”

Mr. Lynch revealed last year that he had emphysema, adding that the lung disease, which he blamed on years of smoking, had limited his mobility and kept him homebound. He later took

to social media amid speculation on his health and the future of his career, writing in a statement, “I am filled with happiness, and I will never retire.”

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‘We will prioritize Mass. families’

In State of Commonwealth, Healey vows to reshape shelter system as part of long agenda

By Matt Stout and Anjali Huynh
GLOBE STAFF

Saying it is time to “build our future,” Governor Maura Healey on Thursday laid out a wide-ranging agenda in her State of the Commonwealth address, vowing to rebuild

roads and bridges, make it easier to get a doctor’s appointment, and transition homeless families out of hotels and motels by the end of the year.

Addressing lawmakers, elected officials, and a primetime audience, the first-term Democrat laced her

near hour-long speech with a series of new plans and calls for the Democratic-led Legislature to join her in realizing her initiatives.

She said she wants to set what she called a permanent “high standard” for high school graduation after voters last year scrapped a decades-old requirement that public school students pass the MCAS exam to get their diploma. She also pledged her administration would

► Shelter proposal draws a mixed response. B1.

review all the state’s business and licensing regulations over the next three months in a bid to cut red tape and make it “cheaper and faster” to do business in the state.

“We’re going to stay focused on the things that matter to you,” Healey said, promising to take steps “to

HEALEY, Page A6



EYAD BABA/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES

Palestinians gathered to receive food aid being distributed Thursday in Deir al-Balah in the central Gaza Strip.

After snags, cease-fire deal finalized

Netanyahu says he’ll convene Cabinet today, prepare for hostages’ return

By Tia Goldenberg, Wafaa Shurafa, and Samy Magdy

ASSOCIATED PRESS

TEL AVIV— Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said Friday that a deal to return hostages held in the Gaza Strip has been reached, after his office said earlier that there were last minute snags in finalizing a cease-fire that would pause 15 months of war.

Netanyahu said he would convene his security Cabinet later Friday, and then the government to approve the long-awaited hostage deal.

Netanyahu’s predawn statement appeared to clear the way for Israeli approval of the deal, which would pause the fighting in the Gaza Strip and see dozens of hostages held by militants in Gaza released in exchange for Palestinian prisoners held by Israel. The deal would also allow



JACK GUEZ/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES

Relatives and supporters of the Israeli hostages hailed the agreement as they celebrated in Tel Aviv.

hundreds of thousands of displaced Palestinians to return to the remains of their homes in Gaza.

Israeli airstrikes, meanwhile,

killed at least 72 people in the war-ravaged territory on Thursday.

Netanyahu said he had instructed a special task force to

prepare to receive the hostages returning from Gaza, and that their families were informed the deal had been reached.

Israel had delayed a vote Thursday on the cease-fire, blaming a last-minute dispute with Hamas for holding up approval as rising tensions in Netanyahu’s government coalition raised concerns about the implementation of the deal just a day after President Biden and key mediator Qatar announced it was complete.

Netanyahu’s office had accused Hamas of reneging on parts of the agreement in an attempt to gain further concessions. In a briefing Thursday, David Mencer, an Israeli government spokesman, said Hamas’s new demands dealt with the deployment of Israeli forces in the Philadelphi corridor, the narrow

GAZA, Page A4

A victory over supremacists, but not enough

Assault victim grateful for \$2.7m judgment but wonders why no one was arrested

By Shelley Murphy
GLOBE STAFF

A Black musician who won a \$2.7 million judgment against the white supremacist group Patriot Front and its leader said he is profoundly grateful for the ruling in his civil rights case but remains troubled by the failure of police to arrest anyone for the 2022 attack on him in Boston’s Back Bay.

“Black people should be able to walk down the Freedom Trail without being attacked by white supremacist organizations,” said 37-year-old Charles M. Murrell III during an interview. “What is it going to take for us to meet this ideal sense of what it means for everybody to have justice, everybody to have equal rights, everybody to be seen as a whole being, no matter their color?”

Murrell, an educator and classically trained musician, was walking along Dartmouth Street on his way to the Boston Public Library to play his saxophone on July 2, 2022, when he was assaulted by members of the Patriot Front during

SUPREMACISTS, Page A7



PAT GREENHOUSE/GLOBE STAFF

“Black people should be able to walk down the Freedom Trail without being attacked by white supremacist organizations,” said Charles M. Murrell III.



Get your mitts off

Friday: Not as cold. High 34-39. Low 27-32.
Saturday: A little rain. High 42-47. Low 33-38.
Sunrise: 7:10 Sunset: 4:39
Weather and Comics, G6-7. Obituaries, C9.

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A Middlesex County grand jury handed down indictments against Dr. Derrick Todd, a prominent rheumatologist accused of sexually assaulting more than 200 patients. **B1.**

President Biden won’t enforce a ban on TikTok, leaving its fate in the hands of President-elect Donald Trump. **B7.**

Worcester officials have launched a civil rights investigation after the first openly trans member of its City Council alleged they were the target of transphobic comments. **B1.**

About 15,000 National Grid gas customers in Massachusetts have not received a bill for months, and say they’re getting no answers. **B5.**

“SNL50: Beyond Saturday Night,” a four-part docuseries on Peacock, isn’t the nostalgia trip on the show’s evolution you might be expecting. **G1.**